City of Cambridge

POR 2026-181
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 28, 2026

COUNCILLOR ZUSY
COUNCILLOR SIMMONS
COUNCILLOR FLAHERTY

WHEREAS: Outer Huron is Cambridge's recreational hub with Fresh Pond Reservation, Russell Community Center (offering programs for teens, seniors, and disabled youth), the Fresh Pond Golf Course, Glacken Field (two little league fields, home of West Cambridge Little League), a tot lot, waterplay area and a basketball and tennis court and is also the home of VFW Mount Auburn Memorial Post 8818; and

WHEREAS: Many using these public amenities regularly drive and need to park to transport heavy sports equipment, youth and seniors; and

WHEREAS: Parking within the abutting neighborhood, Strawberry Hill, is already limited due to the student drop offs and pick-ups and staff parking at the Haggerty School and Parents' Nursery School and parking scarcity will increase with more development; and

WHEREAS: On-street parking along Outer Huron Avenue also serves residents of Parkside Place, a large residential development where 30% of residents are low income, garage parking is rented separately for an additional fee, and a 2021 parking analysis found that approximately 22% of vehicle-owning residents parked on-street along Huron Avenue; and

WHEREAS: Over 1,400 people, including 70 of them from Parkside Place, have signed petitions asking to postpone rolling out these bike lanes because of their negative parking impact; and

WHEREAS: As the Outer Huron Ave. survey shows on page 6, very few cyclists ride along Outer Huron and City data documents that no bike/vehicle accidents were reported as occurring there between 2016 and 2024 – and road speed, a concern shared by Cambridge DOT, could be slowed with traffic calming measures rather than separated bike lanes; and

WHEREAS: Given the City's current fiscal constraints, transportation investments should be carefully evaluated to ensure that available resources are directed toward demonstrated safety needs while minimizing unintended impacts on access to publicly funded municipal amenities, including by prioritizing improvements at intersections and other locations where safety concerns have been identified; and

WHEREAS: These Outer Huron bike lanes were not part of the original Bicycle Safety Ordinance and never prioritized; and

WHEREAS: The argument for them is that they will complete the network, but Belmont won't be implementing the Grove Street Redesign Project, which will feed into them, until at least 2028; and

WHEREAS: The Cycling Safety Ordinance defines "Connectivity" in terms of routes between major origins and destinations in the City (§ 12.22.030(D)), and the Council should therefore assess whether Outer Huron advances that goal while Belmont's Grove Street project remains pending, or whether another qualifying segment could do so with fewer parking and access impacts for nearby residents and users of recreational, senior, and disability programs; and

WHEREAS: The proposed design will eliminate approximately 44 on-street parking spaces from a heavily used area where alternative parking options are limited, with Belmont seeking to keep Grove Street from becoming overflow parking for Cambridge, Parkside Place hesitant to lease spaces to the city, and nearby land uses, including the cemetery and golf course, further limiting opportunities to replace the lost parking; now therefore be it

ORDERED: That the implementation of separated bike lanes on Outer Huron Avenue be postponed for 5 years as this proposal is predicated on too many alternative parking unknowns, and that another half mile of bike lane be swapped in to fulfill the Bicycle Safety Ordinance 25-mile commitment or that the City reduce the BSO obligation to 24.5 miles due to financial constraints as per the ordinance; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to work with City staff and the Bicycle Safety Committee to find another solution to fulfilling the City's obligation to implement 25 miles of separated bike lane network by November 2026 or due to our new financial constraints, modify the commitment.

A true copy;

ATTEST:- Paula M Crane

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk

City of Cambridge

Postponing the roll out of the Outer Huron Bike Lanes from the Bicycle Safety Ordinance until we solve the parking problem.